I would like to thank the Politburo, the Central Committee, my comrades-in-arms in the difficult times of anti-fascist resistance, the members of the party, and all the citizens of our country for all the decades of shared and fruitful activity for the welfare of the people.

I will continue to remain at the disposal of my party with my experience and advice. I wish our party and its leadership continued strengthening of its unity and cohesion and further success to the Central Committee. [Signed] Erich Honecker.6

After eighteen years at the SED's helm, the state-run press poured balm on some of Honecker's wounds by praising his constancy, dedication and dignity. Having completed a round of handshakes and farewells, he returned to Wandlitz rather naïvely expecting a quiet retirement.

Once victory was his, Krenz took over as General Secretary of the SED, Chairman of the State Council and Chairman of the National Defence Council. Posing as a beacon of decency, Krenz promised quick results, 'We are facing work – work, work and more work – but work that should bring pleasure and serve all people.' In usual lickspittle fashion, state television portrayed Krenz as a modern man, a pragmatist. Over in the West, Bild mockingly noted: 'So, the new man is called Egon Krenz. He is to lead the Marx botch-up and shortage republic. For most citizens, Krenz is just as bad as Honecker.'7 In a blunt editorial, Frankfurt Allgemeine Zeitung's commentator Friedrich Karl Fromm, suggested Krenz would have to show results and could no longer rely on a lethargic population, which had been ruled in a totalitarian way for fifty-six years, 'and which basically only asked whether it was possible to make at least some kind of nice living under the prevailing conditions'. The Germans in the GDR wanted more, he argued, saying Honecker's successor didn't have the privilege of being treated with indulgence to which Honecker was entitled: 'He basically wanted good or tolerable conditions, but failed to attain them.'8

A Stasi mood report noted people questioned Krenz's health, 'there's talk of alcohol. He also lacks charisma. Like Honecker, he comes from the youth movement and will continue to spoil them.' Another report compiled on 19